radiating from the centre outwards. India is said to lie in one of the southern petals of the inner row and has the shape of a lotus petal – a peninsula narrowing towards the end and surrounded by the ocean on its sides. Its northern limits were the snow mountains, with Mount Kailash serving as the meru, or central axis. To the west the river Sindhu (Indus) and to the east the ocean, were its boundaries. In both countries, these idealized geographies became deeply embedded in the consciousness of their people and led to notions of a natural and entitled space, despite these idealized geographies being mostly contrary to historical fact.

In these early articulations there was no notion of centrality in either country. In China, the notion of itself as a ‘middle kingdom’ – civilizational centre – came later as China began to see itself as a culturally advanced centre with successive zones of less civilized spaces radiating outwards. In India, the idea of centrality did not take hold, perhaps because of its patent plurality and its constant and sustained encounters with different peoples and cultures through invasions, migrations, trade and commerce. For China, its current geographical expanse – inherited, ironically, from an empire ruled by the foreign Manchus – is the eternal China. In India, the notion of Akhand Bharat is the eternal Indian space, though in its present articulation it harks back to British colonial India.

Just as both countries experienced phases of centralization and fragmentation, they were subject, in parts or in whole, to alien rule and domination at different eras in their history. The Mongol Yuan dynasty (1271–1318 CE) and the Manchu Qing dynasty (1644–1912) in China, and the Mughal (1525–1857) and British empires (1858–1947) in India, were extended periods of alien rule. Each such phase left a mark on each country’s culture, attitudes and thinking; and in its engagement with the outside world. In both India and China there remains a tendency not to acknowledge these influences and to posit instead something that is pristine in its Chineseness or Indianness. In these respects, India and China have similar historical trajectories.

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